Deutsche Bank
Research Institute

I, robot... you, unemployed: How workers are responding to AI fears

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Authors

Michael Kirker
Economist

While media headlines this year have been filled with stories of AI-driven layoffs, less attention has been paid to how workers are responding to the new AI-centric world they find themselves in. Are people so fearful of displacement by AI that they are pulling back on spending and increasing savings? Or are they embracing its potential to enhance their careers and lifestyles?

This research report uses our proprietary dbDataInsights household survey [1] to examine how workers are responding to fears that they will lose their jobs to AI. The analysis shows that, contrary to the idea that worker's fear could slow down the economy as they spend less to boost precautionary savings, individuals most concerned about AI-driven job loss are not retreating. Instead, they are taking some proactive steps.

— **Proactive upskilling:** Workers who are more concerned about losing their job to AI are more likely to undertake AI-related training – potentially in an attempt to complement, rather than be substituted by, AI.

— **Increasing wage demand:** They are more likely than other workers to seek out a pay rise.

— **Confident spending:** They are more likely to be currently spending more, in direct contrast to the idea that greater concern about job security will act as a drag on spending.

The survey also reveals who these concerned individuals are. They tend to be younger, more educated, have a better understanding of AI, and are already using AI in their professional and personal lives.

The findings suggest that workers are not resigned to the fear of losing their jobs to AI. They are attempting to adapt to the new AI world. Supporting this trend – both at the level of individual businesses and broader public policy – could help reduce the social cost of AI adoption that some fear.

[1] For more background on the dbDataInsights household survey see the Annex at the end of this report.

Survey background

Our dbDataInsights household survey asks a wide range of questions each month to nationally representative samples in Germany, France, Italy, Spain, the United Kingdom, and the United States. The analysis in this report draws exclusively from the survey. Respondents to the survey are asked directly about their fears of losing their job to AI:

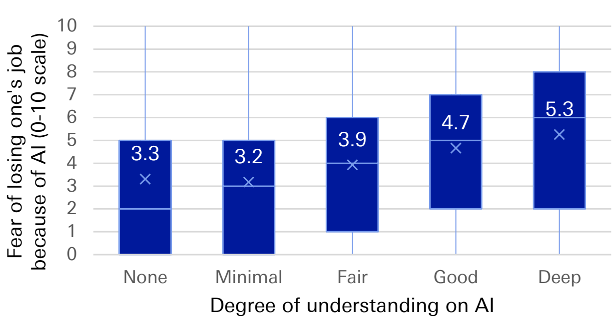
Using a scale of 0 to 10, where 0 is 'Not at all concerned' and 10 is 'Extremely concerned', how concerned are you that you will need to look for a new job within the following time frames because of AI?

This report will focus specifically on the one-year ahead horizon, although results are similar if we consider the two- or five-year ahead horizon instead. We began asking this question in our June 2025 survey round, and the level of concern has been broadly stable since then, both over time and similar across countries. Therefore, this analysis aggregates data from all monthly surveys and countries to maximise statistical power

The fear of losing one's job to AI is not born out of ignorance or irrational fear about AI – it is driven by informed concern. In our survey, those that have a greater understanding of AI show higher levels of concern about losing their jobs.

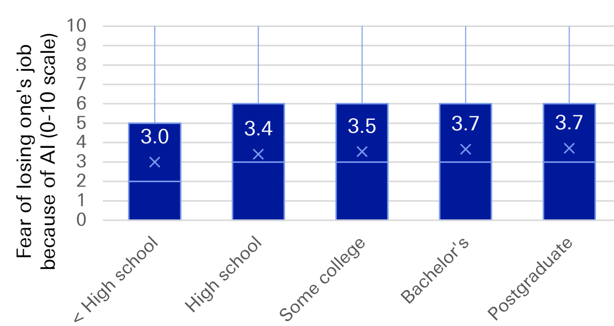
When asked to describe their own knowledge level of AI, respondents who reported higher levels of understanding generally had a higher concern about losing their job to AI than those with less self-reported knowledge (Figure 1). This relationship is not likely to be driven by bias in people's self confidence. **On average, those with higher levels of education also showed higher levels of fear** (Figure 2), and **those who have actively used AI in the past three months either at home or at work – and thus should have greater knowledge about the latest AI developments – also showed greater concern on average about losing their job to AI** (Figure 3).

Figure 1: Those with a higher self-report understanding of AI are also those with the highest level of fear about losing their jobs over the next year



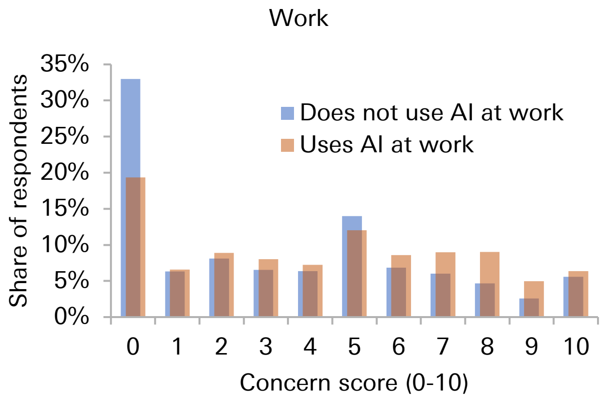
Source : Deutsche Bank Research, dbDataInsights
Notes: Numerical values denote the average fear (on a 0-10 scale) of each group

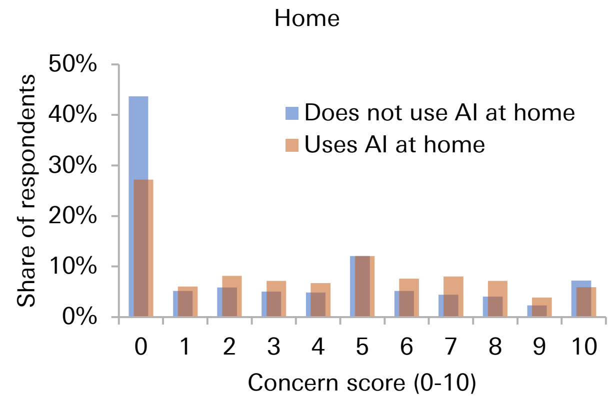
Figure 2: The more educated respondents show more concern about losing their job to AI over the next year



Source : Deutsche Bank Research, dbDataInsights
Notes: Numerical values denote the average fear (on a 0-10 scale) of each group

Figure 3: The distribution of concern about losing one's job to AI over the next year is higher for those respondents who have used AI at work or at home within the last three months





Source : Deutsche Bank Research, dbDataInsights

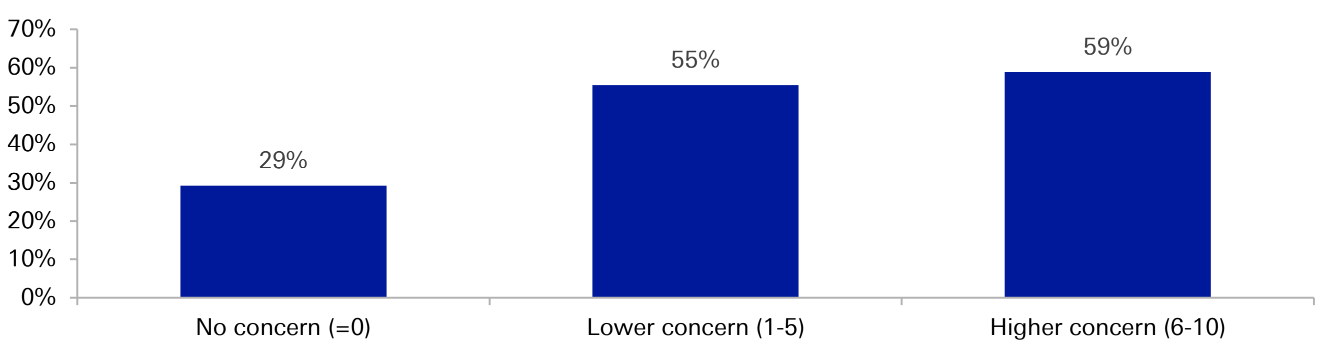
The proactive worker: Upskilling to become a complement to AI rather than a substitute

Worker's fear of losing their job to AI over the next year translates into direct action by the workers. They are not taking the transition to a new AI world lying down. One way in which they are doing this is by upskilling – adapting to become a complement to AI investment rather than a substitute for it.

Up until December 2025, our survey asked respondents what AI learning activities they may have been engaged in: (1) Watching videos to learn about AI; (2) Completing a course to learn more about AI; (3) Reading articles to learn more about AI; or (4) none of these. If the respondent has done any of these types of training (1-3) then they are classified as having undertaken training.

As Figure 4 shows, **the proportion of respondents undertaking some form or AI upskilling/training is increasing with the level of concern about losing one's job to AI over the next year.**

Figure 4: The proportion of respondents undertaking AI training/upskilling is higher for those with higher levels of concern about losing their jobs to AI over the next year



Source : Deutsche Bank Research, dbDataInsights

To work out if the higher likelihood of undertaking training is associated with the level of concern, and not driven by differences in the types of people who are more likely to be concerned, a logit regression analysis is carried out. The regression includes controls for a range of other factors of respondents in an attempt to isolate the effect of concern about job loss on the likelihood of undertaking AI training/ upskilling.[2] The results are shown in the table of Figure 5.

Figure 5: Logit model: Impact of concern about losing one's job to AI on the likelihood of doing AI training

	Share upskilling	Average marginal effect
Full sample	55.3%	1.67pp (SE 0.12)
Only those concerend (concern>0)	61.6%	0.51pp (SE 0.17)

Source : Deutsche Bank Research, dbDataInsights.
Notes: pp = percentage points

The regression is run on the full sample, and then again on the subset who say they have some level of concern (concern >0 on the 0-10 scale). The reason for this is that The change in behaviour from going from "not at all concerned" (a score of 0) to a score of 1 could be quite different from the change in behaviour of someone who is already concerned becoming slightly more concerned (say moving from a 4 to a 5).

The regression analysis shows that a one-unit increase in AI concern (moving one point higher on the 0-10 scale) correlates with a statistically significant average marginal effect of around 1.7 percentage points (pp) for the full sample, and 0.51pp for the concerned subsample. **This means a one-point rise in an individual's concern about losing their job to AI over the next year is, on average, associated with a 0.5-1.7pp increase in the probability of that person undertaking some form of AI training.**

To put that into context, the average level of concern across our survey has risen slightly over half a point over the last year. Therefore, the average respondent has become 0.25-0.9pp more likely to be undertaking some form of AI because of their rising concern about job loss.

This finding is a positive development. Workers are not waiting to be replaced by AI. They are actively working to become AI complements rather than substitutes. If AI does lead to the productivity gains business leaders hope for, tomorrow's labour force are more likely to have the skills and knowledge needed to take advantage of the AI, thereby further boosting the productivity gains from AI.

The pay-rise paradox: Demanding more in the face of disruption

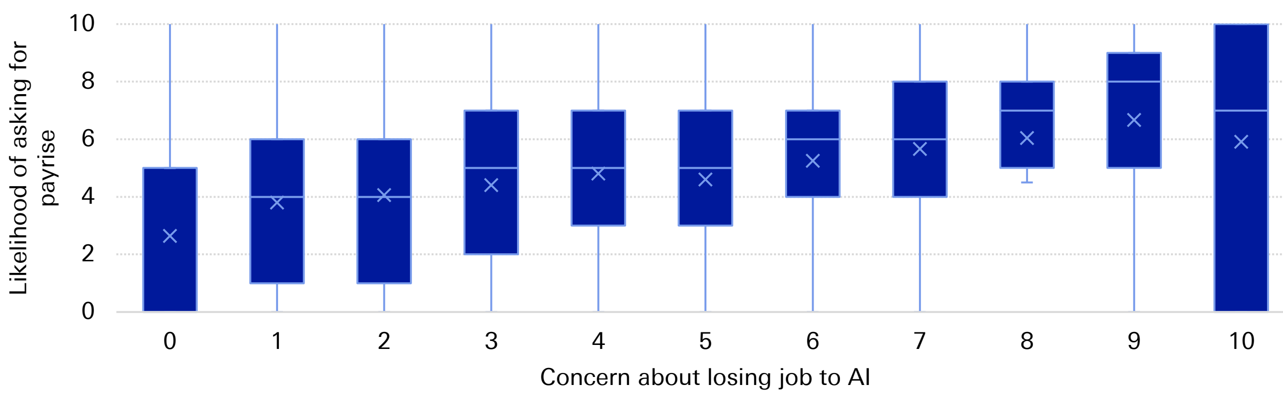
Conventional economic theory would suggest that the because AI is a technology that threatens to replace workers, the adoption of AI by businesses should weaken the bargaining power of workers, making them less likely to push for pay rises.

2 For more on the regression framework used in this report, see Annex 2.

However, the data from our dbDataInsights survey shows the opposite: workers who are more concerned about losing their job to AI are, in fact, more likely to ask for higher wages.

Figure 6 illustrates this paradoxical finding. In our survey, we ask respondents how likely (on a scale of "0 – not at all likely" to "10 – extremely likely") they are to ask their employer for a pay rise in the next three months. Looking at the distribution of responses to this question for each different level of concern about losing one's job to AI over the next year there is a clear pattern of **respondents with higher levels of concern being the most likely to ask for a pay rise in the next three months.**

Figure 6: Paradoxically, workers who report higher levels of concern about losing their jobs to AI are also saying they are more likely to ask for a pay rise in the next three months



Source : Deutsche Bank Research, dbDataInsights

To explore this relationship further, two different forms of regression analysis are used. The first is a panel OLS regression. The results are presented in the table of Figure 7. This approach makes the simplifying assumption that the likelihood of asking for a pay rise is a continuous variable (rather than the discrete 0-10 buckets). The advantage of making this assumption is the coefficient from the regression has a rather simple and intuitive interpretation.

Figure 7: Panel OLS: The impact of concern about AI on the likelihood of asking for a pay rise

	Likelihood of asking for a wage increase (0-10)		Coefficient
	Mean	Median	
Full sample	4.22	5	0.29 (SE 0.01)
Only those concerend (concern>0)	5.01	5	0.30 (SE 0.02)

Source : Deutsche Bank Research, dbDataInsights

The second approach is an ordered logit regression. The results of this are presented in the table of Figure 8. This approach accounts for the discrete buckets for the likelihood of asking for a wage rise, and only requires that the buckets be in ascending order (and not necessarily equally spaced apart).

Figure 8: Ordered Logit: The impact of concern about AI on the likelihood of asking for a pay rise

	Likelihood of asking for a wage increase (0-10)		Odds ratio for a 1pt increase
	Mean	Median	
Full sample	4.22	5	1.21 (95% CI: 1.20, 1.21)
Only those concerend (concern>0)	5.01	5	1.22 (95% CI: 1.20, 1.22)

Source : Deutsche Bank Research, dbDataInsights

Both regression approaches point to the same conclusion. **An increase in the concern about losing one's job in the next year is associated with a higher likelihood of asking for a wage rise in the next three months, even after we control for the characteristics of respondents that are likely to influence their behaviour.**

The panel OLS regression coefficient indicates that a one-point increase in concern about losing one's job to AI (on our 0-10 scale) is associated, on average, with a 0.3 point increase in the likelihood of asking for a pay rise.

So, that would suggest that if an individual's concern about losing their job rose by 3 points on the 0-10 scale, then the likelihood of them asking for a pay rise in the next three months would increase by nearly one point on its 0-10 scale.

The ordered logit gives us an odds ratio of around 1.21-1.22. **That tells us that each one-point increase in the concern of losing one's job to AI is associated with a 21-22% higher likelihood that the individual reporting a higher likelihood of asking for a pay rise in the next three months (than someone with a lower level of concern).**

Why do we find such a counter-intuitive result? It is difficult to say with any certainty. But there are a few theories that could explain the pattern:

- **Omitted Variable Bias:** The regression analysis includes a range of other variables (like the respondents age, whether they are using AI, country-time fixed effects), that attempt to control for factors that could also influence the respondents willingness to ask for a wage rise, and could thus confuse our estimate of the effect from AI job loss concern. But it is possible that the regression does not control for every possibility.

  It's possible that unobserved respondent characteristics influence both concern about losing one's job to AI and the propensity to ask for a wage increase. For instance, ambitious or career-driven individuals might be more inclined to seek pay rises while at the same time are more attuned to both the threats (and opportunities) presented by AI, leading to higher concern as well.

- **Strategic Preparation for Future Redundancy:** Although not reported here, the level of concern about losing one's job to AI over the next year is not too dissimilar to the concern over the next five years. Perhaps workers expect that the time horizon for being replaced by AI is quite long. This could lead them to strategically maximize their current earnings, including seeking higher wages today, in an attempt to bolster future severance payouts or raise their incomes today to build up their savings in anticipation of a future job loss.

The confident consumer: Spending and saving in the AI era

Consumption smoothing behaviour tells us that if workers become more concerned about losing their job in the future, they should reduce their consumption today and save more, thereby having more money available for when they are unemployed.

Thus while spending on AI data centres can boost GDP and economic activity in the near term, at the same time worries about job security can act as a drag on spending, thereby lowering GDP and economic activity.

The results from our household survey present mixed results regarding this behavioural prediction of households. **While workers concerned about losing their job to AI state an intention to save more (a prudent response to uncertainty), they are also more likely to report spending more than this time last year (something that goes against consumption smoothing).**

In the survey, we ask respondents if there are current spending: a lot more; a little more; about the same; a little less; or a lot less, relative to a year ago. Figure 9 shows how the distribution of responses varies by the level of concern about losing one's job to AI. While all groups are more likely to report spending a little or a lot more than last year (a consequence of higher inflation rates), those with a greater level of concern about losing their job are also the ones more likely to report spending more than this time last year.

Figure 9: Respondents who are more concerned about losing their job to AI are also more likely to report spending more than this time last year.

Source : Deutsche Bank Research, dbDataInsights

[Figure 10] reports the results from the ordered logit regression of spending behaviour onto the fear of job loss (and other controls).[3] **The results suggest that each one-point increase in the concern of losing one's job to AI is associated with a 3-6% higher likelihood that the individual reports a higher degree of spending relative to last year.** The result is statistically significant.

Figure 10: Ordered logit: The impact of concern about AI on spending growth

	Odds ratio for a 1pt increase
Full sample	1.032 (95% CI: 1.02, 1.04)
Only those concerend (concern>0)	1.060 (95% CI: 1.05, 1.07)

Source : Deutsche Bank Research, dbDataInsights

This positive correlation between AI concern and increased spending contradicts the initial hypothesis that AI-driven job loss concerns would dampen consumer spending. Spending less would imply a negative correlation (i.e., an odds ratio below 1).

Savings and consuming are two sides of the same coin. It is difficult to accurately measure savings behaviour in household surveys. However, we do ask respondents about their intentions to save. Specifically, respondents are asked: *'Thinking 12 months ahead, do you anticipate your current savings amount(s) will increase, decrease, or remain about the same?' Response options in the survey included: 'Increase significantly,' 'increase slightly,' 'stay about the same,' 'decrease slightly,' or 'decrease significantly.'*

The ordered logit regression analysis was repeated on the savings intension of the survey respondents. The results are presented in the table of Figure 11.

The results suggest that each one-point increase in concern about losing one's job to AI over the next year is associated with a 6-9% higher likelihood that the individual reports a higher intention to save more over the next year.

Figure 11: Ordered logit: The impact of concern about losing one's job to AI on savings intentions

	Odds ratio for a 1pt increase
Full sample	1.06 (95% CI: 1.05, 1.07)
Only those concerend (concern>0)	1.09 (95% CI: 1.08, 1.10)

Source : Deutsche Bank Research, dbDataInsights

3 Inflation expectations is included as an additional control here as it could impact on the decision to bring forward the timing of consumption spending. We also include a control related to the question "are you better or worse off financially than a year ago" as being better off financially than a year ago could explain why the respondent is spending more today than last year.

Thus, a higher concern for losing one's job to AI is, on average, directly associated with an intention to increase savings in the near future. This positive correlation aligns with the concept of precautionary savings, where the perceived heightened risk of AI-induced job in the future loss motivates consumers to save more today.

Thus while the reported spending behaviour of respondents contradicts to predictions that concerned households should be spending less and saving more, those respondents also report a greater intention to save more going forward. But whether they actually follow through on these intentions is not something we can observe. Therefore, the weight of the evidence from our survey suggests that the uncertainty shock from AI fear is not (yet) dampening consumption.

Conclusions and implications

The standard economic theory tells us that workers/households should fear AI. As a substitute for their labour, it weakens their bargaining power and makes it more likely they will be laid off.

But concerns about AI-driven job loss are not creating a passive, fearful workforce poised to retreat from the economy. Instead, our dbDataInsights household survey reveals a powerful paradox: the individuals who are most anxious are also the most proactive, turning their concern into decisive economic action.

- Fear of job-loss from AI is not born out of ignorance. Our survey shows that those who are most informed about AI show the greatest fear of losing their job.
- Workers who are fearful of AI are responding by investing in their own skills and trying to learn more about AI, turning themselves from a type of labour AI can substitute for, to a type of labour that is a complement to AI.
- Rather than weakening worker's bargaining power, fear of AI seems to be encouraging workers to ask for higher wages.
- The confidence also extends to their role as consumers. Higher fear of losing one's job to AI is not associated with workers spending less (savings for the future when they are unemployed). Instead they seem to be spending more.

The key insight from the findings here is that fear of AI is not (yet) acting as a drag on households as standard theory would predict. While businesses are spending big on AI models and data centres, workers are actively trying to adapt to the new world we are moving into. Proactive policies can support workers adapting to AI and lead to productivity gains that go well beyond simply replacing labour with AI tools.

But it must be kept in mind that these findings present only a snapshot of a highly dynamic situation. For now, the 'AI Anxiety Paradox' shows a workforce that is resilient and adaptive. However, these behaviours are rooted in the anticipation of change. Should widespread, large-scale AI-driven layoffs materialise, this dynamic could fundamentally alter, potentially shifting today's proactive ambition back towards a precautionary retreat.

The author would like to thank Anthony Chaimowitz from the dbDataInsights team for his invaluable assistance in administering the survey and collating the data.

Annex 1: dbDataInsights household survey

The dbDataInsights household survey provides valuable insights into household/ consumer attitudes and expectations regarding personal finances, labour market conditions, and buying conditions. The survey is conducted by Deutsche Bank and is used by economists and sector analysis in their research on the macroeconomy and specific sectors.

The survey covers households/consumers in Germany, France, Italy, Spain, the United Kingdom, and the United States. For each country, a national-representative sample of 550 households is surveyed each month (650 households in the US). Results are collected throughout the month to provide a high-frequency look at how expectations and attitudes are evolving in response to the latest developments in the economy.

The survey has been running since 2018 and is continuously evolving to address relevant issues. The survey is conducted online. Although the individual respondents change each month, the panel remains nationally representative each month.

Annex 2: Regression analysis framework

This Annex describes in more detail the regression analysis framework used throughout the report.

To assess the correlation between AI concern and behavior, a series of panel regressions is run using micro-level survey data. In these regressions, the variable of interest (e.g., savings intentions, spending) is regressed against the self-reported concern level, incorporating fixed effects to control for individual respondent characteristics.

Standard fixed effects in most of the analysis account for:

- **Age:** Categorized by ranges (18-24, 25-34, 35-44, 45-55, 55-64, 65+)
- **Using AI:** Binary indicator of whether the respondent has used AI in the last 3 months, either at work or at home.
- **Income Brackets:** Low, medium, and high.
- **Country-Month Interactions:** To capture broader macroeconomic trends (e.g., economic shifts, political events).

Other fixed effects are added where appropriate. For example when examining worker's savings intentions, inflation expectations of the respondents are also included.

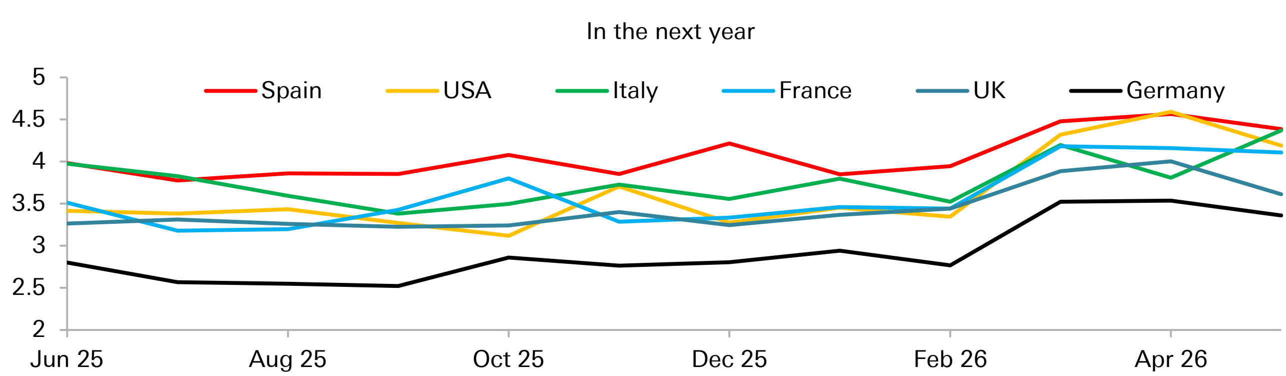
All results in the paper are based on concern of losing one's job to AI over the next year. However, using their concern of losing their job over the next two and five years produce similar results.

Annex 3: Further results about what type of respondents are worried about AI job loss

Figure 12 plots average level of concern in each country we survey (Germany, France, Italy, Spain, the UK, and the US) for each month. A few patterns stand out here:

- **Up until March, the average level of concern was quite stable.** Between June 2025 and February 2026 the average level of concern in all countries remained broadly stable. This period we saw release of some major new LLM models.[4] But the stability of concern shown in Figure 12 suggests the improvement of these models did little to affect the average concern of workers, either because the improvements did not change the opinion of respondents, or respondents may have been ignorant of these latest developments.[5]
- **A shift occurred in March, with average concern rising significantly in all countries.** This increase may be linked to broader geopolitical anxieties, such as the Iran war, which could heighten general economic and financial well-being concerns, making respondents more sensitive to AI-related job loss risks.
- **Across all surveyed nations, Germany consistently records the lowest average level of concern, while Spain registers the highest or near highest.** France, Italy, and the UK show broadly similar levels of concern, though a recent surge in the US has brought its average closer to Spain's level.

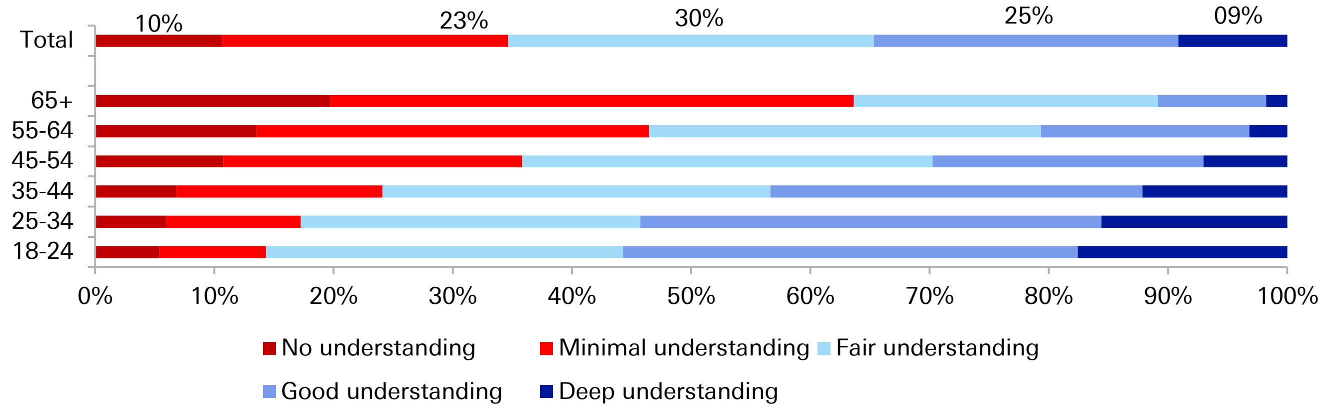
Figure 12: Average concern (scale 0-10) of losing your job to AI



Source : Deutsche Bank Research, dbDataInsights

4 Including OpenAI's GPT-5 (August 2025), Google's Gemini 3.1 Pro (February 2026), etc.
5 However, as shown in Figure 13, a majority of respondents report at least "a fair understanding of AI", suggesting that the new model developments would have likely to have been known by a significant proportion of respondents.

Figure 13: Self reported understanding of AI by age group – The young claim to understand AI better



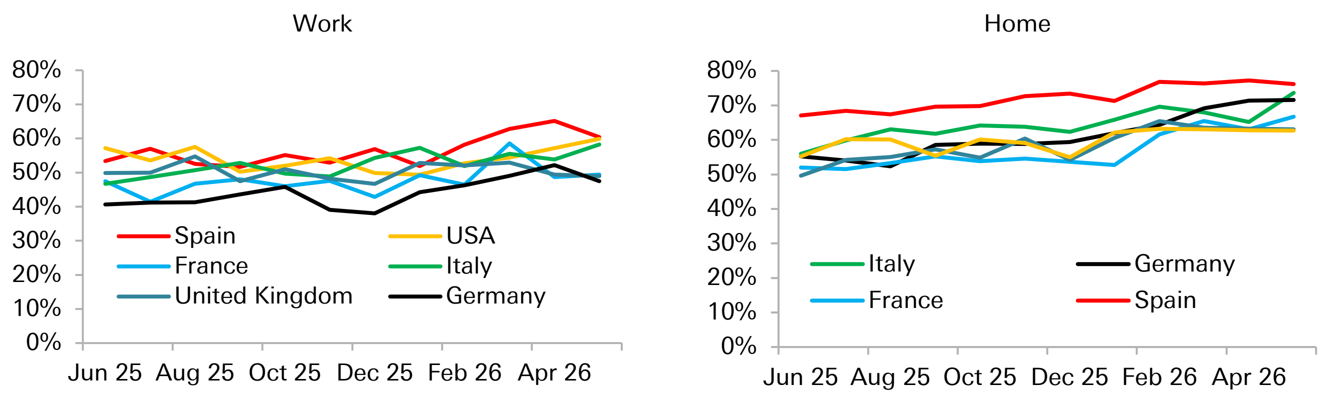
Source : Deutsche Bank, dbDataInsights

Younger individuals also report a higher self-assessed understanding of AI (Figure 13). Younger individuals tend to be more tech-savvy. Their deeper understanding of AI's capabilities likely influences their heightened concern about job loss.

Our survey indicates a strong association between AI usage and elevated concerns about losing one's job to AI. Figure 14 shows the percentage of respondents who have used AI in the last three months, both at work and at home. A few interesting patterns stand out in Figure 14.

- **The proportion of respondents using AI at work is broadly comparable between the US and the European countries we surveyed.** This finding offers some reassurance amidst European political concerns about falling behind in the 'AI race,' suggesting that even without developing as many cutting-edge models of their own, European businesses are effectively leveraging existing AI tools.
- **While US respondents show similar rates of AI usage at work and home, in Europe, home usage generally surpasses work usage.** This could signal a greater appetite among European workers for integrating AI into their professional lives, provided they are granted more autonomy with the tools.
- **AI adoption, both at work and at home, is steadily increasing.** Across all surveyed countries, the percentage of respondents using AI in the past three months shows a consistent upwards trend.

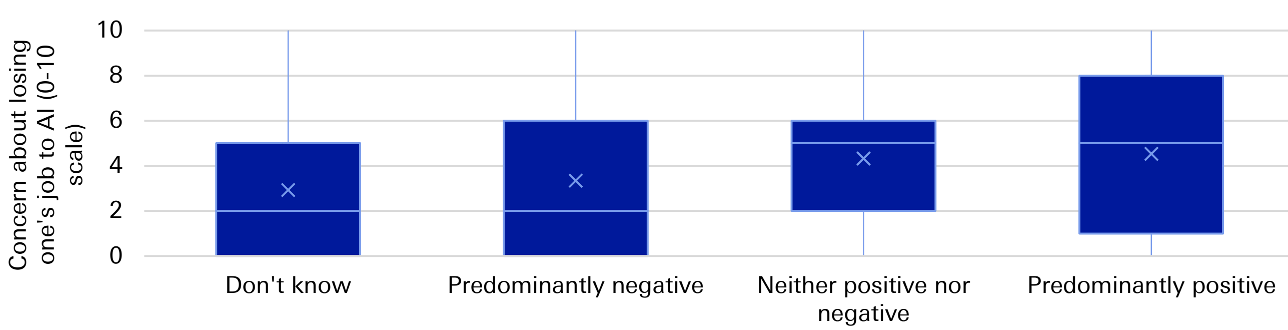
Figure 14: Share of respondents who have used AI in the last 3 months at…



Source : Deutsche Bank Research, dbDataInsights

Those with a more positive outlook on AI's societal impact also demonstrate the highest concern about losing their own jobs (Figure 15). This pattern suggests that techno-optimism/pessimism may not be the primary determinant of individual job security concerns.

Figure 15: Those thinking AI will have a more positive social impact are the most concerned about losing their jobs to AI



Source : Deutsche Bank Research, dbDataInsights

Appendix 1

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